

Read the System

Enough systems literacy to deploy, debug honesty, and not brick the mouth - without becoming a full engineer overnight.

Source: General subject pack (Gate-tied) - companion to docs 05, 10, 12

One sentence

A system is inputs -> state -> outputs -> side effects. Your job is to know which box the irreversible write lives in.

Request / response

- Client asks (browser, curl, Stripe webhook). Server answers with status + body.
- 2xx usually means success path. 4xx you/client problem. 5xx server broke - fail-closed territory.
- JSON body is structured claims. Read keys that name law: ok, halt, write_executed, their_production.

Where config lives

- Environment variables: secrets and public URL outside the code (Stripe keys, GATE_*, Render env).
- Never paste live secrets into a PDF, chat dump, or git commit.
- If checkout 404s or deposit fails, check: route deployed, price/payment link set, public URL correct.

Deploy mental model

- Code on a branch != live mouth. Merge + deploy + curl the URLs.
- Friday rule: diligence page, one-pager, offer.json, checkout must return success before sends.
- Museum demos can be up while their_production stays false. Honesty bit is part of the system.

What broke? (triage order)

- DNS / wrong host - are you hitting gate.velaru.xyz or a stale preview?
- Route missing - 404 means deploy or path wrong, not 'philosophy failed'.
- Env missing - Stripe/price unset often becomes soft failure or fallback link.
- Upstream timeout - Velaru/verify unreachable should DENY, not silent allow.
- Logic bug - invariant violated (write_executed true on clearance). Treat as severity max.

Logs without drowning

- Reproduce once with curl. Save status code + one JSON field that matters.
- Change one variable. Redeploy or restart. Curl again.
- If you cannot state expected vs actual in one sentence, you are not debugging yet.

Minimal map for this week

- GET /diligence - human money face
- GET /diligence/one-pager.txt - shareable claim
- GET /diligence/offer.json - machine offer
- Checkout / payment link - deposit path
- POST /v1/act - clearance ask (not the wire)
- Velaru verify - stranger-openable proof surface

Retrieval drill

- Define input, state, output, side effect for a payout.
- Explain why merge without deploy leaves outbound lying.
- List triage order when /diligence 404s.

What this is not

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- Not a CS degree
- Not permission to rewrite the worker before Friday sends
- Not replacing doc 12 - this is systems; 12 is code-map